command was drafted, seeking a change in leadership, arguing that Warring's face would hurt the party in 2027. Their choice? Channi.

The group has resolved to boycott Warring's official engagements, pending a seven-day 'ultimatum' to the Centre. A foretaste of that came as several of these leaders skipped Baghel's official sessions, choosing instead to huddle with Channi at his residence in Morinda. They have authorised Channi to meet party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, general secretary K.C. Venugopal and former president Rahul Gandhi and convey their sentiments.

Takeaways

- **Congress faces rebellion after retaining Raja Warring as Punjab chief ahead of 2027 election**
- **The leadership battle has become a contest between Jat Sikh dominance and Dalit representation**

For students of Punjab politics, the moment carried a sense of déjà vu. In 2015, the party's MLAs had similarly rallied behind Captain Amarinder Singh, defying the high command. Only Amarinder had the stature to unite the Congress and take on the Akali Dal-BJP regime, they argued. New Delhi relented. Today, the chief insurrectionist has changed. Another element, too, seems to be departing from the 2015 script: the high command has refused to blink.

Instead, there came an elaborate balancing act. Channi was made chairman of the campaign committee, former deputy CM Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Vijay Inder Singla and MP Dr Amar Singh were given charge of three other committees. Dalit leaders Sukhwinder Singh Danny, Raj Kumar Verka as well as OBC face Sangat Singh Gilzian were made working presidents. On paper, every major faction and social group had been accommodated. In reality, the critics saw committee chairs as a poor consolation prize that could not substitute for resolving the leadership question.

CHANGING SOCIAL MOOD

At its core, the battle reflects changing social dynamics. Warring, a Jat Sikh, upholds the traditional pyramid—the community has long held the sceptre despite being just a fifth of the population. Channi is a different proposition. As Punjab's first Dalit CM, he is the party's tallest Scheduled Caste leader. Punjab has India's highest Dalit ratio at 32 per cent, so this is hardly trivial. Channi is a Ramdassia Sikh; with the Hindu Ravidasias and Addharmis, the sub-group weighs in at 16 per cent, the second biggest bloc after Jat Sikhs. His camp says returning to a Jat Sikh leadership will confound the party's messaging.

If Warring has survived sustained leadership challenges since he took charge in 2022, that's a function of the party's deep divisions. Seniors have openly questioned his style, criticised his decisions and lobbied Delhi for a change. Recent assembly bypolls became proxy factional battles. In Ludhiana West, where Warring is the sitting MP, Bharat Bhushan Ashu's campaign saw him get a limited role. At Tarn Taran, Warring was blamed for failing to connect with voters. Fair or not, the perception that Warring had become a liability had taken hold.

Yet, when the high command finally had the chance to replace him, it chose status quo. That may prove costly in one of the few major states where the Congress believes it has a realistic chance. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

DKS Draws Up Welfare Map Anew

The flagship guarantees are a costly budget item. The new CM makes sure their targeting isn't amiss

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

THE WELFARE MANIFESTO THAT swept the Congress to power in 2023 always had its fiscal doubters. Its flagship schemes, which reach up to 16.5 million households, have cost the exchequer a cumulative Rs 1.21 lakh crore across three fiscals. For at least two years now, voices have been calling for efficient targeting to ensure there's no spillage from that massive head of water. With a fresh start under D.K. Shivakumar, who took charge as chief minister in June, that call appears to have been heeded. While DKS broadened the welfare ambit with schemes of his own, he has also ordered a re-mapping of older schemes with the highest budgetary outgo.

The concerns are focused especially around Gruha Lakshmi, under which a monthly Rs 2,000 allowance is wired to the bank accounts of women who are heads of households. An ongoing audit by the Accountant General has flagged several lacunae, like money going to dead beneficiaries or multiple women with the same account number. The irregularities amounted to Rs 225 crore, the agency noted, seeking details of deletions in the beneficiary table. The scheme, which reaches an estimated 12.4 million women, is the biggest of the five guarantees rolled out in 2023: at Rs 75,180 crore over three fiscal years.